

THE 30 MINUTES

5 min	10 min	12 min	3 min
HOOK	TEACH	ACTIVITY	CLOSING

OVERVIEW

Students learn to evaluate the credibility of visual and written sources, identify bias, and distinguish between primary and secondary sources using the CRAAP test framework.

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

What students will understand

Students will evaluate the credibility of visual and written sources using the CRAAP test, identify indicators of bias, and distinguish between primary and secondary sources in order to become more discerning consumers of information.

STANDARDS ALIGNMENT

CCSS.ELA-LITERACY.RI.6.8: Trace and evaluate the argument and specific claims in a text, distinguishing claims that are supported by reasons and evidence from claims that are not.

CCSS.ELA-LITERACY.W.7.8: Gather relevant information from multiple print and digital sources, using search terms effectively; assess the credibility and accuracy of each source.

MATERIALS NEEDED

- Spirit photography examples (1860s–1900s) — available online or in Mini Museum materials
- Modern deepfake example or manipulated image (age-appropriate)
- Two articles about the same event from different perspectives
- CRAAP test poster or handout (included in student materials)
- 3–4 sources for practice evaluation (mix of reliable and unreliable)
- Optional: Student handouts (three levels available)

HOOK · 5 MINUTES

The Ghost in the Photograph

Display a spirit photograph from the 1860s–1900s (William Mumler's work is a good example).

> *"This photograph was taken in the 1860s. The photographer charged grieving families a lot of money because he claimed he could photograph the spirits of their dead loved ones. Look at it carefully. Do you think it's real?"*

Let students share initial reactions. Then reveal: *"This is a fake. The photographer used a technique called double exposure to add 'ghosts' to his pictures. He made a fortune before being exposed as a fraud."*

> *"People have been manipulating images since photography was invented. Today we have Photoshop and AI deepfakes. The technology changes, but the challenge remains the same: How do we know what to believe? Today, you're going to learn a systematic way to evaluate ANY source — visual or written — so you can protect yourself from being fooled."*

DIRECT INSTRUCTION · 10 MINUTES

The CRAAP Test

"Librarians and researchers use something called the CRAAP test to evaluate sources. Yes, it's a funny name — but it helps you remember it!"

C
Currency

When was this created or updated?

Is the information recent enough for your topic?

Are links functional? Is the site maintained?

For images: When was the photo actually taken vs. when was it shared?

R
Relevance

Does this relate to your needs?

Does it answer your question?

Who is the intended audience?

Is it at an appropriate level?

A
Authority

Who created this?

Who is the author/creator? What are their credentials?

Is there contact information?

What does the URL tell you? (.edu, .gov, .org, .com)

A
Accuracy

Is the information correct?

Can you verify this information elsewhere?

Are sources cited?

Are there spelling/grammar errors (often a red flag)?

For images: Has this been altered? Does reverse image search show different contexts?

P
Purpose

Why does this exist?

Is it trying to inform, persuade, sell, or entertain?

Is it fact, opinion, or propaganda?

Does the author/creator have a bias or agenda?

For images: Was this created to document reality or to manipulate emotions?

ACTIVITY · 12 MINUTES

Evaluating Real Sources

Part 1: Practice Together (5 minutes) — Display a clearly unreliable source (example: a satirical news site, an outdated webpage, or a heavily biased blog). Walk through the CRAAP test together:

- *"Let's check Currency first. When was this written?"*
- *"Who's the Authority here? Can we find information about the author?"*
- *"What's the Purpose? Is this trying to inform us or persuade us?"*

Part 2: Independent/Partner Practice (7 minutes) — Provide 2–3 sources for students to evaluate (mix of reliable and unreliable). Students can work individually or in pairs to apply the CRAAP test.

Suggested sources to include:

- A Wikipedia article (discuss: useful starting point, but check the citations)
- A news article from a reputable source
- A clearly biased website or social media post
- An image shared out of context (reverse image search reveals the truth)

CLOSING · 3 MINUTES

Primary vs. Secondary Sources

> *"One more important distinction: Primary sources are original, firsthand accounts — a photograph taken at an event, a diary entry, an interview. Secondary sources analyze or interpret primary sources — a textbook chapter, a documentary, a news article about something."*
>
> *"Neither is automatically better, but knowing the difference matters. The spirit photographs we saw were PRIMARY sources — but they were still fake! Primary doesn't mean true. You still need to apply the CRAAP test."*

MINI MUSEUM CONNECTION

Option 1 — Visit the Mini Museum: The exhibition includes Victorian optical illusion cards and a stereoscope — both of which demonstrate how Victorians were fascinated by visual trickery. Spirit photography exploited this fascination AND people's grief. The same principles apply today: manipulated images exploit our emotions and our trust in visual "evidence."

Option 2 — Virtual Visit: Explore the exhibition online, or view individual artifacts at minimuseumproject.org/exhibitions/seeing-is-deceiving/artifacts

minimuseumproject.org/exhibitions/seeing-is-deceiving

ASSESSMENT

Formative: During partner practice, circulate and listen for correct application of CRAAP criteria.

Exit ticket: "Name two CRAAP criteria you'll use most often when evaluating sources, and explain why those matter most to you."

Extension: Students find a viral image or claim online and write a CRAAP analysis of it.

DIFFERENTIATED STUDENT HANDOUTS

Three levels of student handouts are provided as separate files. Students self-select their challenge level:

GREEN LEVEL MORE SUPPORT	YELLOW LEVEL GRADE LEVEL	RED LEVEL GO DEEPER
"I want more support" — CRAAP checklist with guided questions, evaluate one source together	"I'm ready for a challenge" — Apply CRAAP test to 2–3 sources independently	"I want to go deeper" — Find real misinformation, analyze how it spread, create verification guide

TEACHER RESOURCES & BACKGROUND

Background: spirit photography

William H. Mumler (1832–1884) was a Boston jewelry engraver who "discovered" he could photograph spirits in 1861. He charged $10 per photograph (about $350 today) to grieving families who wanted images of their deceased loved ones. His most famous client was Mary Todd Lincoln, who received a photograph showing Abraham Lincoln's "ghost" behind her.

Mumler was put on trial for fraud in 1869. Photographers testified that his technique was simple double exposure — he used previously exposed plates to superimpose faint images onto new photographs. Despite strong evidence, Mumler was acquitted because the prosecution couldn't definitively prove HOW the fakes were made. He continued practicing until his death.

WHY THIS HISTORY MATTERS TODAY

Spirit photography teaches students several important lessons:

- **Visual evidence has always been manipulable** — This isn't a new problem created by Photoshop or AI
- **Emotional vulnerability increases susceptibility** — Mumler targeted grieving families; modern misinformation often targets fear, anger, or hope
- **Primary sources can still be fake** — Students often assume "original" means "true"
- **Proof is complicated** — Even when experts knew the photos were fake, they couldn't prove it in court

RECOMMENDED SOURCE EXAMPLES FOR CLASS

Clearly Unreliable:

- The Onion or Babylon Bee articles (satirical)
- Outdated medical advice websites
- Anonymous blogs with no citations
- Social media posts with emotional language

Generally Reliable:

- Associated Press, Reuters (wire services)
- Encyclopedia Britannica
- .gov and .edu websites
- Peer-reviewed journals (for older students)

FACT-CHECKING RESOURCES FOR STUDENTS

- **Snopes.com** — General fact-checking, urban legends, viral claims
- **FactCheck.org** — Political claims and statements
- **Google Reverse Image Search** — Find original source of images
- **TinEye.com** — Another reverse image search tool
- **AllSides.com** — Shows media bias ratings for news sources

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO ADDRESS

- **"If it's on the news, it must be true"** — News sources have varying levels of reliability and bias
- **"Wikipedia is never reliable"** — It's a good starting point; the key is checking the citations
- **"I can always tell if an image is fake"** — Modern deepfakes are increasingly sophisticated
- **"Primary sources are always better"** — They're original, but not automatically true or unbiased